

The stranger

*In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine
And special guest – Lindail Raven Queen's Palladin*

The road was empty in the way roads went empty at dusk — not abandoned, but holding its breath, waiting to see what the dark would bring. Blackhoof and Briggs had been walking the perimeter for two hours, and the most interesting thing they had encountered so far was a fox, which Briggs had regarded with professional suspicion before concluding it was merely a fox. Blackhoof asked, with complete seriousness, if he can cuddle it. Briggs didn't answer.

Time was passing - as usual - with a speed of high quality honey, dripping from the spoon.

"There," said Briggs.

Blackhoof looked. A figure on the road — a man, moving at the unhurried pace of someone who either didn't know there was a goblin army camped half a mile east or didn't particularly care. Travelling alone. Cloaked. In the last light of the evening, something about his face caught the dusk differently than a face should.

"Alone," Blackhoof said.

"So far," said Briggs, in the tone that meant so far was doing considerable work in that sentence. "Come on."

They moved to intercept with the efficiency of two people who had done this before — Blackhoof wide to the left, cutting off the road ahead, Briggs coming in from the right at an angle that left the stranger nowhere comfortable to go. The stranger stopped. He did not reach for a weapon. He did not run. He simply stood and watched them approach with the calm of someone who had been intercepted before and had opinions about it.

Up close, the face resolved into something that was not quite human. Golden skin that caught the last light and held it. Eyes the colour of winter sky, pale and without particular concern. A jawline that suggested either very good breeding or divine interference, and given the rest of it, probably the latter.

Briggs looked at him for a long moment.

"Asimaras," he said quietly, which was not a greeting so much as a field identification.

The stranger inclined his head, which could have meant anything.

"Who are you," Briggs said. "Where are you going. Why are you on this road."

The stranger listened to all three questions with polite attention. Then he opened his mouth and spoke.

"Buonasera. Chiedo scusa per l'intrusione — non era mia intenzione causare allarme. Sono un viandante, niente di più."

Briggs stared at him.

The stranger waited.

Briggs looked at Blackhoof. Blackhoof looked at Briggs. Neither of them said anything for a moment.

"Did you understand any of that?" Blackhoof asked.

"No," said Briggs.

"It was very musical."

"It was completely useless." Briggs turned back to the stranger. "Who. Are. You." He spoke slowly and at increased volume, in the manner of a man who suspected that the problem might be a matter of projection.

“Mi dispiace, non capisco la vostra lingua. Parlo asimarano — forse c’è qualcuno nel vostro accampamento che potrebbe aiutarci?”

“He speaks more slowly now,” Blackhoof observed. “Like he thinks the problem is you.”

“I am going to need you,” Briggs said, “to be less amused by this.”

“I’m not amused.”

“You’re extremely amused.”

“I’m professionally neutral.” Blackhoof looked at the stranger with an expression that was, in fact, professionally neutral in the same way a summer sky is professionally cloudy. “Try asking again. Maybe louder.”

Briggs tried louder.

“Capisco che stiate cercando di comunicare,” the stranger said, with the gentle patience of a man watching children attempt something difficult, “ma urlare più forte non cambierà la lingua.”

“He said something,” Blackhoof said.

“I’m aware he said something.”

“It sounded almost like a complete thought.”

“Blackhoof.”

“I’m just noting—”

“I know what you’re noting. Stop noting it.” Briggs pulled his hands through his hair with the expression of a man reaching the outer limits of his operational patience. He turned back to the stranger, planted his feet, and tried a completely different approach: gestures. He pointed at the stranger. Raised his hands in a question. Pointed down the road. Mimed, with considerable dignity, the act of walking and then arriving somewhere and then — after a brief pause in which he clearly reconsidered his life — being either welcomed or turned away.

The stranger watched this performance with genuine interest.

“Ah, volete sapere dove sono diretto? Affascinante mimo, davvero.”

“He’s complimenting you,” Blackhoof said.

“You don’t know that.”

“His tone was very complimentary.”

“His tone could be anything. His tone is in a language I don’t speak.” Briggs looked at the stranger, who looked back at him with polite golden patience, and made a decision. “We’re taking him in. Gord speaks something — I don’t know what, but more than us. Come on.”

He gestured, firmly and unambiguously, in the direction of camp. The stranger considered this for a moment, then nodded and fell into step beside them as though this had been his idea all along.

Blackhoof fell in on the other side and caught the stranger’s eye briefly. The stranger smiled — small, genuine, the smile of a man who was finding the evening more interesting than expected.

Blackhoof smiled back before he could stop himself.

“Il tuo amico è molto... intenso,” the stranger said quietly, nodding toward Briggs.

“I have absolutely no idea what you just said,” Blackhoof told him pleasantly, “but you’re probably right.”

Lieutenant Gord was a goblin of middle years and considerable self-importance, currently occupied with his supper when they arrived at his tent. He looked at the stranger. He looked at Briggs. He set down his spoon with the resigned expression of a man whose supper was never going to be finished hot.

“Languages,” Briggs said. “You speak them.”

"Several," Gord replied.

"Does one of them sound like—" Briggs paused. "Blackhoof, describe it."

"Musical," Blackhoof said. "Flowing. Many vowels. The words are long but they arrive pleasantly."

Gord looked at the stranger for a long moment. Then, carefully, with the expression of a man excavating something from considerable depth:

"Bon-giorno. Voi... siete di dove?"

The stranger blinked at the greeting — it was distinctly evening but rallied admirably.

"Buonasera, signore. Vengo da lontano — sono un servo della Regina dei Corvi, in pellegrinaggio. Non cerco guai, vi assicuro."

Gord nodded slowly, processing this. Then:

"La... Regina dei... Corvo? Questo è un... pericoloso... divinità, no?"

"La Regina dei Corvi," the stranger corrected gently, "non è una divinità da temere per chi rispetta il ciclo naturale della vita e della morte. Sono qui in pace, non in guerra."

Gord absorbed this, trying to swallow it instead of his supper. He turned to Briggs.

"He serves something called the Raven Queen. Death goddess, more or less. He says he's a pilgrim. Passing through."

"Pilgrim," Briggs repeated.

"That's what he says."

"On this road. At dusk."

"Correct."

Briggs looked at the stranger, who met his gaze with the specific equanimity of a man who had been looked at skeptically by better and hadn't particularly minded.

"Ask him what he wants," Briggs said.

Gord turned back. "Cosa... volete? Da noi? Cosa cercate?"

"Niente che voi possiate darmi, temo. Cerco solo la strada. La mia signora mi guida, e la strada mi porta dove devo andare. Chiedo solo il permesso di passare."

Gord translated. Briggs listened. He looked at the stranger for a long time — the unhurried look he used for things he was reading carefully.

Then as an upper rank, he decided:

"Let him go," he said.

Briggs blinked. "Just like that?"

"He's a pilgrim following a death goddess across a road at sunset. Either he's exactly what he says he is, or he's something considerably above our pay grade."

Briggs picked up Gord's abandoned spoon and handed it back to him. "Finish your supper. I'll write the report."

They walked the stranger back to the road.

At the edge of camp, where the torchlight gave way to open dark, the stranger stopped. He turned to face them both, and inclined his head — a gesture that managed to be neither submissive nor dismissive, simply a recognition of something completed between equals.

"Grazie," he said. "Siete stati più gentili di quanto vi fosse richiesto."

Then he reached up, and moved his cloak aside.

The wings caught the torchlight as they opened — wide, raven black, the span of them filling the dark with sudden impossible geometry. Blackhoof took an involuntary step back. Beside him, Briggs went very still, with the expression of a man recalibrating several assumptions simultaneously.

The stranger looked at them.

Something passed across his face that was almost amusement, and almost sympathy, and was entirely its own thing.

He lifted, once, with a sound like wind finding a sail — and then he was up, the wingbeats steady and unhurried, climbing into the dark above the treeline with the ease of something that had never needed roads to begin with.

Blackhoof watched him go.

He watched until the shape of the wings was indistinguishable from the stars, and then he watched a little longer, because the sky was very large and the figure had become very small and the distance between the two seemed, at this particular moment, like the most interesting thing in the world.

To fly like that. To look down at roads and armies and goblin camps and all the careful earthbound arrangement of things, and simply — go. To follow a horizon not because the army pointed there but because the air itself was open and the world was wide and nothing below had any particular claim on you.

What would be waiting, he thought, if the army wasn't.

Behind him, Briggs cleared his throat.

"Perimeter," he said. "We're not done."

"I know," said Blackhoof, voice here, but his mind somewhere really distant.

Eventually he turned away from the sky and fell into step beside his sergeant, and neither of them said anything about the wings, or the height, or the particular way Blackhoof had looked at the dark for just a little too long.

Briggs noted it anyway.

He always did.

